



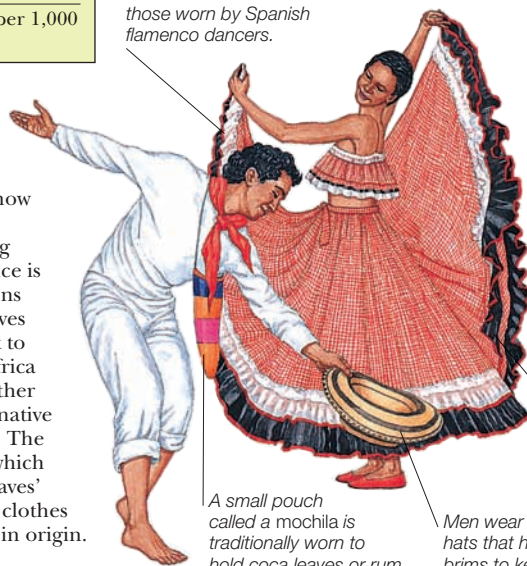
## COLOMBIA

**Capital city:** Bogotá**Area:** 439,733 sq miles  
(1,138,910 sq km)**Population:** 44,200,000**Official language:**  
Spanish**Major religions:** Christian  
95%, other 5%**Government:** Multiparty  
democracy**Currency:** Colombian  
peso**Adult literacy rate:** 92%**Life expectancy:** 72 years**People per doctor:** 833**Televisions:** 217 per 1,000  
people

## CARTAGENA

The bustling port of Cartagena was founded by the Spanish in the 1500s. Great Spanish galleons bound for home set off from here piled high with riches looted from the native peoples. The old city walls, enclosing beautiful mansions and churches, are still there today, along with the many fortifications built by the Spanish to ward off pirates and attacks from other countries.

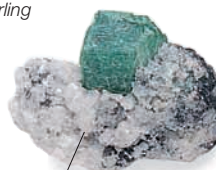
*The women's skirts look like those worn by Spanish flamenco dancers.*



*A small pouch called a mochila is traditionally worn to hold coca leaves or rum.*

*Men wear sombreros – hats that have wide brims to keep off the sun.*

*Skirts have weights in the hems to keep them from swirling too high.*



*Veins of natural emeralds are found in rocks such as calcite or pyrite.*



*About 500 statues have been found at San Agustín. Many are shaped like birds or animals.*

## COLOMBIA

WHEN SPANISH CONQUERORS reached Colombia in 1499, they discovered a civilization that was rich in gold. They spread tales of a mysterious lost city called *El Dorado*, filled with wealth, but it has never been found. Since 1819, when Colombia became an independent country, it has suffered decades of violent political battles and, more recently, bloody rivalry between drug cartels. Today Colombia is the world's largest producer of cocaine. Large rivers, such as the Orinoco and Amazon, form an important means of transportation for goods across the country.

## BURIED TREASURE

Mining has become very important to the Colombian economy since large deposits of oil were found northeast of Bogotá. Petrochemical plants, like this one at Barranquilla, convert oil into fuel for cars and planes. New sources of coal, the largest in Latin America, as well as deposits of nickel, are also helping boost the economy. The US, and Venezuela are Colombia's main trading partners.



## THE CUMBIA

All Colombians know how to dance the *cumbia*, even young children. The dance is a blend of traditions from the black slaves who were brought to Colombia from Africa in the 1800s, together with Spanish and native Indian influences. The men wear white, which was the color of slaves' clothes. Women's clothes are more Spanish in origin.

## AGRICULTURE

The variety of climate zones in Colombia means that a wide range of crops can be grown. For many years coffee was the country's main export and Colombia is still the world's third largest producer. Once picked, coffee beans are spread out in trays to dry naturally in the sun. Falling world coffee prices have forced Colombia's farmers to develop other products, such as sugar, bananas, cotton, and cut flowers, which are all grown for export.



## EMERALDS

Many people consider Colombian emeralds to be the finest in the world. The earliest civilizations to live in this region made beautiful objects from gold and emeralds. Today, Colombia produces more than half of the world's emeralds.

## SAN AGUSTIN

This small village near the southern mountains is famous for its ancient stone figures. The statues are at least 800 years old, but very little is known about the people who carved them. Some experts believe that the site was a ceremonial center where the Agustínians buried their dead, placing statues near the tombs.

## Find out more

COFFEE: 50, 66

DRUG TRADE: 58

GEMSTONES: 172, 191

OIL: 137, 152, 281